

Relationship of Passion and Burnout Among Indian Para-Athletes

Sargun Kaur Sethi¹, Guneet Inder Jit Kaur²

ABSTRACT

Para Athletes have been the most remarkable set of athletes as they have shown resilience in the face of obstacles. Their contribution to Indian Sports has been par excellence and they continue to grow tremendously in the arena of sports. Covid-19 has recently impacted the world and left indelible mark on everyone, more so the athletes. The face of competition has changed and has brought about challenging circumstances. Thus, as India gears up for 2024 Paris Olympics, the psychological profile of athletes and more so the disabled athletes are of prime importance. Research into the psychological indicators is needed to understand the mental and physical health of para-athletes. The objective of this study was to understand the relationship between Passion (Obsessive passion and Harmonious passion) and Burnout among Indian Parathletes. The samples comprised of 15 Parathletes (3 females and 12 males) under the Divyang Para-sports Association of Rajasthan and were actively involved in individual sports at the International, National and State Levels and were in sports of swimming, athletics and shooting. The para-athletes included in the study had impairments like leg length difference, arm deficiency, spinal cord injury, paraplegia and were within the age range of 18-48 years. The questionnaires used were the Vallerand 17-point Passion scale, and the Athlete burnout questionnaire. The statistics used were Descriptive analysis (Mean, Standard deviation) and inferential analysis (Pearson product-moment correlation). The results showed an intricate relationship between the two variables. The study has immense applications in the field of intervention for para-athletes.

KEYWORDS: Para athletes, Passion, Burnout, Excellence, Mental training.

¹ M.Sc. Department of Sports Psychology, Central University of Rajasthan

² Assistant Professor, Department of Sports Psychology, Central University of Rajasthan,

INTRODUCTION

India being the biggest contender today in paralympic games has been in focus as a potential podium finisher for the upcoming Paris Paralympics 2024. According to International Paralympic Committee, Paralympic games emphasize equality. Going by the Motto-“United by Emotions”. The meaning of Paralympics is parallel game beside Olympics. In 1960s the 1st Paralympics were held in Rome and 400 athletes participated among 23 countries whereas there was a drastic increase in 2008 Summer Paralympics in Beijing where 4,000 athletes participated from 146 countries. (Bawden, 2006; DePauw & Gavron, 2005; Gilbert & Schantz, 2008). The initial Paralympics observed addressed a shift in personality traits, mental & physical development during grassroot training and an upsurge in performance (Blumenstein et al., 2015). Para-athlete was described as a handicapped athlete who has participated at the highest-level for the country like the World Championships or Paralympics, and, has out skilled in his sport through continuous achievement (Swann, Moran, & Piggott, 2014). Para-athletes are more indulged in sports as it develops the health holistically and has a positive impact on mental health and social outlook. Requirement of Psychological skill training in para sports to help improve performance, inclination of para-athletes on intrinsic motivation. (Baker et al., 2021)

Passion

Valler and et al (2003) stated that passion is a drive for an activity of interest, a characteristic which is important, and devote time, mind, energy on it. The two-fold model for Passion explains two types of passion: - negative (Obsessive) and positive (Harmonious) passion concepts (Vallerand, 2010).

Harmonious Passion denotes to "a powerful urge" and is the after effect of *a u t o n o m o u s (i n d e p e n d e n t)* internalization where uninhibitedly people enthusiastically acknowledge the activity (or item) as significant, (Marsh et al., 2013). This feeling of willing involvement is related with volition and individual support (Vallerand et al., 2010), where people easily engross in the movement as opposed to feeling a sense to be bound to do such activity (Vallerand et al., 2003).

Obsessive Passion means to "a sturdy irrepressible need to participate in the action" (Belanger, Lafreniere, Vallerand, and Kruglanski, 2012), and is the after effect of controlled incorporation where stress is felt because of the insight of possibilities (Vallerand et al., 2010). A study has shown that children who are in independent surroundings tend to be harmoniously passionate in sports while children intensely describe themselves via their sports and their parents have high regards for their sport are more incline towards being obsessively passionate. (Mageau et al., 2009)

Athlete Burnout

Athlete burnout having many components like emotional/physical exhaustion, reduced sense of accomplishment, devaluation of sport participation. (Raedeke, 1997). It is the negative effect of excess working out, with insufficient recovery. Onset of burnout - chronic stress for long duration, helplessness to encounter situation needs. The subdimensions of Athletic Burnout are as follows:

Reduced sense of accomplishment –

Athletes question and doubt sports skill and ability to be successful. Lack of goals, plans, - incompetence, inadequate feelings, no satisfaction. Training hard – minimal progress

Sport Devaluation – Loss of interest, psychological

Emotional/Physical exhaustion- Due to stress of competitions, high training loads. State of physical, emotional and mental depletion

METHODOLOGY

This study used a mixed method approach and employed both quantitative and qualitative research design. The quantitative research design was correlational in nature, in order to assess the relationship of Passion and Burnout, the qualitative research design was used to explore the nature of the concerned variables amongst Indian Para-athletes.

Due to rarity of the sample non-parametric- purposive sampling methods were used. Para-athletes of State, National and International level under Divyang Para Sports Association of Rajasthan undergoing training were selected. All athletes who fit the inclusion criteria were selected.

The current study included 15 Indian Para-athletes in Quantitative approach and the study included 2 Indian Para-athletes in qualitative research design research which was based on interviews often seeking an in-depth understanding of the phenomenon of interest beyond peripheral manifested meanings. This thus requires the researcher to be absorbed in the research field, to establish productive rapport with the participants and through theoretical reflection to address the research problem in depth. Therefore, a small number of cases (less than 20) have been found to aid the researcher's close alliance with respondents, and enhance the validity of in-depth investigation in naturalistic settings (Crouch & McKenzie, 2006).

The tools used were in the form of questionnaires:

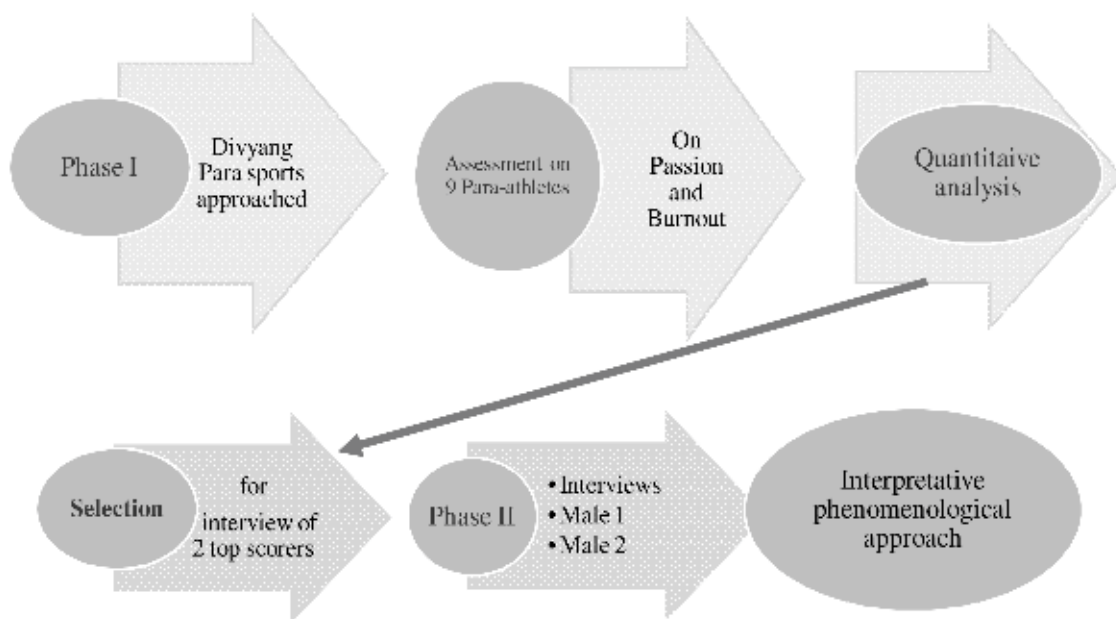
17-pt Passion Scale: It consists of 17 items, with no inverse items, distributed into three sub-scales: harmonious passion (items 1, 3, 5, 6, 8, 10), obsessive passion (items 2, 4, 7, 9, 11, 12) and passion criteria (items 13-17). Responses are given on a Likert-type scale from 1 to 7, where 1 signifies "not agree at all" and 7 "very strongly agree". Scores of

reliabilities on the Passion Scale have ranged from .78 to .88 (Marsh et al., 2013).

Athlete Burnout Questionnaire (ABQ): It has three subdimensions: (1) devaluation of sports participation, (2) a reduced sense of accomplishment, and (3) emotional and physical exhaustion. Athletes were asked to consider to what extent each item reflects their feelings towards their sport participation on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (“Almost Never”) to 5 (“Almost Always”). A global burnout score was computed as described by Raedeke & Smith (2001). The reliability and the factorial and convergent/divergent validity of the ABQ are supported in previous research. Cronbach’s alphas

were 0.85, 0.86, and 0.76 for emotional and physical exhaustion, devaluation of sports participation, and a reduced sense of accomplishment, respectively.

This study included approaching the different sports centers to identify and select the Para-athletes who are undergoing training. With the consent of the concerned sports authority/Coaches and respective athletes who fit in the present research sample criteria were approached via telephone/email. They were briefed about the research objective using Google forms for Informed Consent, Socio Demographic Sheet Passion scale. The procedure that was carried out is explained below in the figure:



Representation of data collection procedure:

Translation of the English form into Hindi and then from Hindi to English was done by two professionals who are fluent in Hindi and English language respectively and was also shown to a sports Psychologist.

The obtained data was organized as per the objectives of the study and appropriate statistical tests were used for analysis of quantitative data like Descriptive Analysis (Means, SD's) and Spearman's Rho correlation. For the qualitative data, interpretative phenomenological approach was carried out.

RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

The study followed a mixed method approach. The sample comprised of 15 (12 males and 3 females) Para-athletes from Rajasthan for assessment, out of which 2 para-athletes were selected for interview. The total sample included 1 International player, 6 National players and 8 State players.

The quantitative data collected was scored and subjected to descriptive statistics. Since the data was found to be not normally distributed in the group, spearman's rank correlation coefficient (Spearman's rho) was used to find the correlation between passion and burnout further Interpretative phenomenological approach was done for the Qualitative

data obtained from the interviews. The mean of passion is 18.17 and S.D. is 2.13. The mean of Burnout is 24.99 with S.D. 8.11.

Table 1: Correlation co-efficient value (Spearman's rho) between Passion, and athlete burnout (N=15)

Variables	OP	HP	PCr	D	E	RA
OP		-0.26	0.03	0.12	0.30	0.53*
HP			0.63*	-0.40	-0.46	0.04
PCr				-0.52*	-0.19	0.10
D					0.47	0.16
E						-0.13
RA						

**Correlation is significant at 0.01 level (2-tailed)

*Correlation is significant at 0.05 level (2-tailed)

As the data is collected from Indian para-athletes, in which majority of them are males and are employed which might affect their sense of contribution towards their passion i.e., their sport. Research has shown that individuals off-task thoughts at work and on-task thoughts off-work may intervene passion and sense of engagement.

The Qualitative data was divided into further two subdimensions which were bifurcated further. The 2 sub dimensions are Nature and Psychosocial factors.

Nature

Theme	Sub-Theme	Statements
Passion	Concept of Passion	Male (1) “जूनून.... जैसे एक पागलपन..किसी खेल के प्रति” “Passion.... like a madness towards a game” “स्पोर्ट्स के लिए ऐसे तुक्का लगाने वाला नहीं है इसमें म्हणत ज़रूरी है जूनून ज़रूरी है” “There is no such pun for sports, it requires hard work, passion is necessary.” Male (2) “जूनून एक अपने आप अंदर से फीलिंग लानी पड़ती है की मेरको ये करना है ये नहीं की कर लेंगे” “Passion, one has to bring a feeling from within itself that I have to do this, not that I will manage it.”
Burnout	Mind connection body in burnout	Male (1) “अपना स्वस्थ सही रखो...डेली प्रैक्टिस करो” “Take care of your health...practice daily” Male (2) “खेल है, तो खेल इसको ये नहीं मैडल के लिए मत खेले इसको खेल की भावना से खेल...खेल की भावना से अगर खेलते है तो आपको मैडल हंड्रेड परसेंट लगेगा...मैडल की भावना...स्पोर्ट्स में सक्सेसफुल नहीं हो सकते” “Its sports, so play it not for a medal, play it with the spirit of the game... if you will play it with game spirit you will get a medal 100%... with the intent of getting a medal...successful in sports is not possible” “योगा करो...मैडिटेशन करो आप ये आपके माई को रिलैक्स करेगा” "Do yoga... do meditation, it will relax your mind"

From the above responses of participants, the nature of passion, burnout can be described as attaining resilience, having the determination to stand all alone believing in oneself and doing all that one could lead to the maximum possible results in sports. He works towards his sport with an "I am unstoppable" mindset

and disciplined life, focusing on both physical and mental well-being and enjoying the process. He believes in himself and has this perception that one grows by meeting new people taking away their positives and it's really helpful in relaxing the thoughts which run in our mind every day.

Psychosocial factors

Theme	Sub-Theme	Statements
Passion	Positive affect and persistence	Male (1) “जूनून...जो करना है वो करना है जी जान लगानी है...फिर जितना हो सकता है वो करिये” “Passion...., you have to do it, then do whatever you want” “जूनून.....फायदे फिटनेस बॉडी.... प्लस इसमें आप घर में रहने के बजाय अगर एक दो घंटे आप खेल में ध्यान देंगे तो माई प्रेश रहता है “ Passion.... Benefits of fitness body...Plus, instead of staying at home, if you pay attention to the game for a couple of hours, then the mind remains fresh” Male (2) “आप कभी भी नेगेटिव में नहीं आओगे हर टाइम पॉजिटिव में” “You will never be negative but positive all the time”
	Sport based resilience	Male (1) “हंड्रेड परसेंट डिसेबिलिटी है मेरी... मेरा राइट हैंड खराब है तोह मै इससे जेवलिन या शॉट पूत नहीं कर सकता हु तोह स्विमिंग... लगा ऐसा लगा की नहीं कर पाउँगा आगे नहीं जा पा रहा था वेलेंस नहीं बन रहा था... धीरे धीरे तरीका समझ में आया... तैरना चाहिए” “I have Hundred percent disability... my right hand is bad, so I can't do javelin or shot put with it, so swimming...felt like I would not be able to go forward, was not getting balance...slowly understood the way... should swim” Male (2) “स्पोर्ट्सपर्सन आपको एक विलपॉवर देगा की अरे भाया आप इतना अच्छा कर रहे हो” “Sportsperson will give you a willpower that hey man you are doing so well”
Burnout	Financial Reasons	Male (1) “स्पोर्ट्स खेलने के लिए थोड़ा पैसा चाहिए दस बारह हजार रुपैये हर महीने इन्वेस्ट करने...” “Need some money to play sports, investment of ten twelve thousand rupees every month” Male (2) “खेल पे जूनून...ऐसा नुक्सान लगता नहीं है अगर फैमिली साथ है तोह...फैमिली अगर आपको सप्पोर्ट नहीं करती है तोह आपको नुक्सान...आपकी लाइफ स्पोर्ट्स की जगह फिर वो और कही सेटल नहीं होती है” Passion on sports... it doesn't feel like a loss if family is with you...if family doesn't support you then it's a loss to you...Your life doesn't get settled anywhere else apart from sports”

	Time management/ Work-Life balance	Male (1) “बस ऐसे मेन्टेन करना पड़ता है घर वालों के साथ... टाइमिंग कब आना है हमको... किसके साथ में...कैसे स्विमिंग पूल से निकलना है” “Just need to maintain it with family members...Timing when do we need to come... with whom... how to get out of the swimming pool” “जॉब के लिए तोह टाइम मैनेज करना पड़ा है...जैसे अभी बच्ची को लेके आया हु साथ स्विमिंग पूल जब जाना है जब उस टाइम हमीफ्र है” “I have learned to manage time for job...like have brought my daughter today... when I have to go to the swimming pool... whenever we are free at that time.” Male (2) खेल पे जूनून...ऐसा नुकसान लगता नहीं है अगर फैमिली साथ है तोह...फैमिली अगर आपको सपोर्ट नहीं करती है तोह आपको नुकसान...आपकी लाइफ स्पोर्ट्स की जगह फ्रि वो और कही सेटल नहीं होती है” Passion on sports... it doesn't feel like a loss if family is with you...if family doesn't support you then it's a loss to you...Your life doesn't get settled anywhere else apart from sports”
--	---------------------------------------	---

To summarize the results of qualitative data which have drawn attention on consistency in working hard on being a better version of ourselves by having a keen interest in learning every day by meeting new people, shifting our thoughts from negative to positive and focusing a lot of attention on health irrespective of disabilities. Despite battling with death these Para-athletes have attained a very high resilience as they try to excel in whatever their mind is into and ignore the people or situations who try to pull them down. Since they are involved in one of the biggest famous industries which involve an investment of at least 15 thousand Rs per month they need to be financially solid. They are very

concerned about trying to maintain a balance between family and sports and equally give time to everything. The Para-athlete focuses on how development is linked to meeting new people learning and how to learn from many international Para-athletes who have achieved so much but are not letting their achievement hamper their performance. At last, they believe that nothing happens in a day it all requires time and energy which should have a constant graph in their day-to-day activities.

CONCLUSION

The results have proved the first null hypothesis and have found that there is no

significant relationship between Passion and Burnout among Indian Para-athletes. Although, there is no significant relationship observed between the variables per se, a significant positive correlation has emerged between passion and two dimensions of burnout i.e, reduced sense of accomplishment and devaluation. Thus, this study provides a startling insight and observation that as passion increases, devaluation decreases, reduced sense of accomplishment increases when an athlete is having obsessive passion. Thus, the quantitative and qualitative approach in this study provide insight in the significant positive correlation between obsessive passion and reduced sense of accomplishment, significant negative relationship between devaluation and passion as the majority of Indian Para-athletes are employed males which affects their involvement in sports. The nature of passion, burnout was described as being mentally tough, disciplined and determined for a fixed goal and doing all that is in your control to succeed in this one goal. The psychosocial factors of passion, burnout

indicate that there is a direct relationship between learning and growth, patience, maintaining a healthy balanced life and having a keen behavior towards learning are other psychosocial factors that are needed to be taken care of. Due to the scarcity of samples, sampling error could have affected results which are a true reflection of ground reality. The different stake holders were not considered in this study which could have added more value to the results. Future studies could focus on different personality variables more importantly resilience and other protective psychological factors. Longitudinal studies could be attempted on the present sample to understand the long-term effects of the variables. Intervention studies focusing on reducing burnout could be undertaken based on the insights gained from the qualitative part of this study. Studies on psychological profile of Para-athletes from different regions/sport/disability could be attempted. Qualitative research with the caregivers and coaches of para-athletes could be done to understand their perspectives and contributions.

REFERENCES

1. **Baker, H.P. et al. (2021).** The injury rate in National Football League players increased following cancellation of preseason games because of COVID-19, Arthroscopy, Sports Medicine, and Rehabilitation, 3(4).
2. **Bawden, M. (2006).** Providing sport psychology support for athletes with disabilities. In J. Dosil (Ed.), The sport psychologist's handbook: A guide for sport-specific performance enhancement (pp. 665–683). Chichester, UK: John Wiley & Sons.
3. **Bélanger, J. J.; Lafrenière, M.-A. K.; Vallerand, R. J. & Kruglanski, A. W. (2013).**

When passion makes the heart grow colder: The role of passion in alternative goal suppression. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 104(1), 126–147.

4. **Blumenstein, B. and Orbach, I. (2015).** Psychological preparation for paralympic athletes: A preliminary study, *Adapted Physical Activity Quarterly*, 32(3), pp. 241–255.
5. **Crouch, M. and McKenzie, H. (2006).** The logic of small samples in interview-based qualitative research, *Social Science Information*, 45(4), pp. 483–499.
6. **DePauw, K.P. & Gavron, S.J. (2005).** Disability sport (2nd ed.). Champaign, IL: Human Kinetics.
7. **Gilbert, K. & Schantz, O.J. (2008).** The Paralympic games: Empowerment or side show? New York: Meyer and Meyer.
8. **Lopes, M. & Vallerand, R. J. (2020).** The role of passion, need satisfaction, and conflict in athletes' perceptions of burnout. *Psychology of Sport and Exercise*, 48, Article 101674.
9. **Mageau, G. A.; Vallerand, R. J.; Charest, J.; Salvy, S. J.; Lacaille, N.; Bouffard, T. et al. (2009).** On the development of harmonious and obsessive passion: The role of autonomy support, activity valuation, and identity processes. *Journal of Personality*, 77, 601–645.
10. **Marsh, H. W.; Vallerand, R. J.; Lafrenière, M. K.; Parker, P.; Morin, A. J.; Carbonneau, N.; Abduljabbar, A. S. (2013).** Passion: does one scale fit all? Construct validity of two-factor passion scale and psychometric invariance over different activities and languages. *Psychological Assessment*, 25(3), 796–809.
11. **Martin, E. and Horn, T. (2013).** The Role of Athletic Identity and Passion in Predicting Burnout in Adolescent Female Athletes. *The Sport Psychologist*, 27(4), pp.338-348.
12. **Martínez-Alvarado, J.; Aguiar Palacios, L.; Chávez-Flores, Y.; Berengüí, R.; Asadi-González, A. and Magallanes Rodríguez, A. (2021).** Burnout, Positivity and Passion in Young Mexican Athletes: The Mediating Effect of Social Support. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, 18(4), p.1757.
13. **Raedeke, T. D. (1997).** Is athlete burnout more than stress? A commitment perspective. *Journal of Sport and Exercise Psychology*, 19, 396–417.
14. **Raedeke, T. D. & Smith, A. L. (2001).** Development and preliminary validation of an athlete burnout measure. *Journal of Sport and Exercise Psychology*, 23, 281–306.
15. **Swann, C.; Moran, A. and Piggott, D. (2015)** Defining elite athletes: Issues in the study of expert performance in sport psychology, *Psychology of Sport and Exercise*, 16, pp. 3–14.
16. **Vallerand, R. J.; Blanchard, C.; Mageau, G. A.; Koestner, R.; Ratelle, C.; Leonard, M. & Gagne, M. (2003).** Les passions de l'âme: On obsessive and harmonious Passion. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 85(4), 756–767.
17. **Vallerand, R. J.; Paquet, Y.; Philippe, F. L. & Charest, J. (2010).** On the role of passion for work in burnout: A process model. *Journal of Personality*, 78(1), 289–312.